General rule – Languages and communication · SRD 5.2.1

A character speaks **Common** plus **two other languages** of their choice (from their background). Languages are **standard** or **rare**. A language has no separate script: if you speak it, you write it.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Every character speaks **Common** + **2 languages** of choice.
2. **Standard languages**: available at creation.
3. **Rare languages**: with the DM's approval.
4. Useful spells: **Comprehend Languages**, **Tongues**.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 lists standard and rare languages and ties languages to the background, not species.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say how to communicate without a shared language. Fix: gestures, drawing, miming, with a **Charisma (Influence)** check at DC 15 for a simple message.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can have NPCs speak in their own language (accent, key words) and let players guess.

Step 1 – Choose:

Common + two languages from the list (standard preferably).

Step 2 – Speak:

Two creatures who speak the same language understand each other.

Step 3 – No shared language:

Gestures, drawings: Charisma (Influence) check DC 15 for a simple message.

Step 4 – Magic:

Comprehend Languages understands; *Tongues* lets you speak and understand.

Step 5 – Secret languages:

Druidic and **Thieves' Cant** are known only to their initiates.

Example: Lira speaks Common, Elvish and Sylvan. She talks with a dryad in Sylvan, then summarizes for her group.

Standard	Rare
Common	Abyssal
Common Sign Language	Celestial
Draconic	Deep Speech
Dwarvish	Druidic
Elvish	Infernal
Giant	Primordial
Gnomish	Sylvan
Goblin	Thieves' Cant
Halfling	Undercommon
Orc	—

⚠ Common questions:

How many languages at start?

Common + 2 of choice.

Which languages are standard?

Common, Dwarvish, Elvish, Giant, Gnomish, Goblin, Halfling, Orc, Draconic, Common Sign Language.

And rare ones?

Abyssal, Celestial, Deep Speech, Infernal, Primordial, Sylvan, Undercommon.

Must I know how to read?

No, you read what you speak.

Can I learn a language?

Yes, during downtime.

Does a spell read writing?

Yes, Comprehend Languages.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Separate script

Does a language have its own alphabet? **Option**: yes, to learn.

Dialects

Can I speak a dialect? **Option**: Charisma disadvantage.

Learning

How long? **Option**: 250 days, 1 gp per day.

Sign language

Can I sign silently? **Option**: yes, in line of sight.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Druidic

Secret language: only druids understand it.

Thieves' Cant

Rogues' secret code.

Telepathy

It doesn't replace a language.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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